

train us in the way of a growth mindset. One that is not fixed but gives way to refinement, experiencing the fruit of our efforts, and more realized potential inside ourselves. It will also help us move away from the all-or-nothing, catastrophizing, overgeneralizing ways of thinking and live more in the reality of the present as we give ourselves space to think more critically in a nonjudgmental manner. Not that we still won't be drawn to these unhelpful thinking patterns, but we can catch ourselves and gently move to a place of better thinking. Which inevitably leads to better, more informed actions.

I went through these steps of curiosity when my husband, Eric, and I were hit with an unexpected hefty tax bill. In addition to needing to fork over money that I had not previously planned to give to Uncle Sam, I was also navigating feelings of shame, failure, embarrassment, and frustration. "I'm the cohost of a personal finance podcast, how did I not see this coming? How did I not plan for this? How do I make sure *nobody* finds out about this?" I questioned myself, my abilities, even my fit-ness for talking about money to a large audience when I'm sitting in my accountant's office with a lump in my throat trying to do ninja-math, meanwhile recognizing that another unexpected bill could mean financial ruin.

I was catastrophizing, immediately going to the worst-case scenario in my head. I even set a rule for Eric and me that we couldn't ride our scooters for the next month because, in my mind, if we got in an accident that would mean a large medical bill that could potentially bankrupt us. I am laughing now as I write this, but the circumstances at the time truly felt dire to me. Of course I was forgetting about the emergency fund we still had, the insurance (albeit sucky) that would help offset costs of medical needs, and don't forget all my knowledge of negotiating, saving, and spending better (thanks to Jen and my Frugal Friends community)! None of that mattered in the face of failure. Yet as I **created space** to take some deep breaths, spoke to a few trusted friends, and was challenged to bring some contrasting thoughts and facts to the situation, I was able to **observe objectively** and **inquire inquisitively**. My healthier, more curious, inner monologue went something like this: "What led me to think that this year I did not need to set a percentage aside for taxes?" Notice the non-why question!

Turns out it is a very common mistake (even according to tax experts) for people with multiple W2s to not select extra withholding when needed. As I **assessed** both the facts and my emotions about it all, I realized that this was